

Was Jesus *Really* Tempted?

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The story of the temptation of Jesus seems to have a strange setting, indeed. A baptismal service was being conducted in the Jordan River, and John the Baptist was the minister. John was not cut from the cloth of conventional propriety. Quite the contrary, his message of repentance departed from the norm. His attire was a camel's skin suit held in place by a leather girdle. His favorite meal was grasshoppers and wild honey. John was the Grizzly Adams of the religious right, a fashion disaster whose diet was never copied.

A phenomenon unlike anything current religious leaders had ever witnessed was occurring. Though his habits were unorthodox and his preaching anything but consoling, great multitudes followed John. The impact of this unconventional ministry would be felt for more than two thousand years.

Immediately following the baptism of one candidate, John looked up to see a young man approaching from the distant horizon. As the man drew nearer, John recognized the familiar stride of his cousin Jesus. His greeting rang loud with prophetic overtones: "*Behold the lamb of God which taketh away the sins of the world.*" People in the crowd held their breaths; eyes darted left and right to glimpse this anticipated wonder. Even for John, certainly not one who minced words, the pronouncement was uncharacteristically bold. Every Jewish person in this throng understood the meaning of a sacrificial lamb. But in his declaration about his cousin Jesus, John not only declared Jesus Himself to be *a* lamb—and not only a lamb, but "*the* Lamb of God" that would "take away the sins of the world." This Lamb, John was declaring, would attain a threshold of achievement no other lamb through the centuries had been able to attain, though untold thousands had meekly given their lives.

Following such prophetic affirmation, you might expect Jesus to begin building a ministry that could touch the entire earth. Yet, true to His unconventional manner, He does nothing of the sort. In fact, He seems to downplay John's startling revelation by requesting to be baptized.

It is then that a wonderful phenomenon occurs. A dove defies its nature and makes physical contact with a human being, and a voice booms from the sky saying, "This is my

beloved Son in whom I am well pleased." Afterwards, a most amazing episode begins. Jesus is "led of the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil." Just when most casual readers expect Him to "maximize the moment", or "strike while the iron is hot", Jesus goes into seclusion!

THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN TEMPTATION AND TESTING

Driven by the Spirit into the wilderness, Jesus passes the days fasting and praying to His Father. At the end of forty days, He emerges and is immediately confronted by Satan. The encounter is popularly called the "temptation of Jesus" because of Satan's impudent attempt to entice the Lord through appeals to His carnal desires.

Most likely, these temptations took place over a few days, at best. What then do we make of the entire wilderness experience? Why was Jesus thrust into isolation? Why was He compelled to fast and commune with God at the genesis of His ministry? Did He endure forty days of fasting simply to be faithful during a few days of temptation?

Jesus was tempted, yes. And yet, His temptation was only part of a greater experience. In the wilderness, alone with His father, attended by the Holy Spirit, Jesus was *tested*—conditioned and examined—for the work that followed. His character was rigorously scrutinized in much the same way a structural engineer tests a vessel or pipeline to prove its integrity.

How can we be sure that "testing"—not temptation—was God's kind intention for His Son? First, the Bible teaches that temptation is self-inflicted (James 1:13-14). Temptations are born of evil desires found in the heart of man, exploited by Satan to entice us to sin, terminate our influence, separate us from close fellowship with God, and destroy the destiny God has chosen for us.

Testing, on the other hand, is allowed by our Heavenly Father to strengthen us, build our faith, prepare us for greatness, and develop character that can stand the onslaught of success and failure.

The testing of Jesus had nothing to do with a moral lapse. It was allowed by God to examine the purity of His heart through His reaction to presentations which appealed to the lust of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life (1 John 2:15-17). In three calculated temptations by Satan, God tested the integrity of Jesus in areas common to every man—body, soul, and spirit. The Lord's testing was universal in its impact. His experience is our textbook. His faithfulness is our example. So complete was the Lord's victory, God was pleased to record the matter for eternity in Matthew 4:1-11.

“*The lust of the flesh.*” Jesus had received no nourishment in forty days. Was He hungry? He was starving! Satan attempted to entice Him to use His supernatural abilities to satisfy fleshly desires.

“*The lust of the eyes.*” Satan tried to incite Jesus to cast Himself down from the pinnacle of the Temple, thus using His divine power to do something contrary to natural and divine law. Had he done so, Jesus would have picked up again the mantle of His divinity and forever forsaken the humility of His condensation. Jesus would have demonstrated that He was the Son of God, but mankind would have forever lost an Elder Brother in the godhead, one who is like us in all things, except sin.

“*The pride of life.*” Satan led Jesus to a high mountain and promised to give Him all He could see if He would bow down and worship. Satan’s appeal to Jesus is a warning to every true servant of Christ! In due season, every believer is destined to rule as a king and priest. How dangerous it is to desire promotion too quickly, or to worship the wrong things, or to attempt to reign over territory not intended for us. Because of our predisposition for worshipping and reigning, many tests that come our way will be spiritual in nature.

THE VULNERABILITY OF TEMPTATION

(James 1:12-15)

There are three basic sources of the temptations or tests we all face.

First, *we are tested by things God allows*. This testing has limits. Our spiritual growth and character have been deemed sufficient for the test. I see no record in Scripture of anyone failing a test that was pre-approved by God.

Second, *we are tempted by the enemy*. God never sanctions temptation that allows for moral failure. The enemy cannot force us to sin; the devil did not make you do it! He can do no more than make a brief presentation of the temptation.

Third, *we are tempted by own desires*. By our own volition and imagination, we follow the trail of carnal desires until entrapped in a web of shame and failure. Look at the life of Samson. He was called to be a Nazarite and a deliverer for Israel. The Spirit of the Lord moved upon him from time to time, enabling him to accomplish heroic feats. Carnal lusts long unchallenged in his heart led him to Delilah. Eventually he told her the secret of his success. She sold him out, and Samson lost his power with God. He was blinded and made a circus attraction.

Samson's story is all too familiar to Christians who never deal with sinful attractions of the heart and mind.

Temptation is an enticement to do what is in violation of biblical instruction. According to the Word, God cannot be tempted by evil, and will not authorize us to be tempted to do evil! Therefore, any enticement to do what is contrary to the Word of God is from Satan himself! If the attack against us carries this component— if our response to it causes us to disobey any portion of Scripture—it is a covert attack and must be dealt with as such. We must fight it using all the weapons at our disposal. We must “throw the book”—the Bible—at the devil from the outset. This kind of attack is normally won or lost at the point of impact.

Almost unknowingly, many Christians meekly place themselves in vulnerable positions. Others fail to implement a “search and destroy mentality” at the moment of initial temptation. Either way, we can easily succumb to an enemy who is absolutely merciless when he discovers the helplessness of his victim.

THE PROTECTION OF TESTING

You are probably thinking that Jesus faced the same temptations we do yet He did not sin. It's true! The Bible states it very vigorously in Hebrews 4:15. So what kind of temptation did Jesus face?

- He was restricted by the limitations of the flesh. He became hungry. In Matthew 4, this was the first way the enemy tested Him.
- He became physically exhausted. Several times in Scripture He removed Himself from the crowd for some rest and relaxation.
- He became lonely. "Foxes have holes, birds have nests, but the Son of Man does not have a place to lay His head."
- He suffered rejection. Crowds left Him because of His teachings, and even one of the twelve betrayed Him. His inner circle did not understand His mission, even at the end. As Jesus agonized in prayer in the Garden of Gethsemane, Peter, James and John could not tarry with Him for one hour. We can almost hear the sadness in the Lord's voice: "Sleep on now."
- He endured conflict within His family. Do you think Mary and Joseph were happy parents when their twelve-year-old son went missing for three days?

- He was tempted to get angry and lose His temper. Imagine the emotions that surged through Him as He dealt with moneychangers in the Temple.
- He suffered physical pain. The ordeal of His crucifixion would cause any other man to seek an easier path.

Though Jesus was *tested* in many ways, there is no shred of evidence that He was *tempted* to do anything which conflicted with biblical commandments! Did the idea of doing a selfish deed or walking the road of convenience ever enter His mind? I'm sure it did, but He knew the power of casting imaginations down upon impact. This is where our battle with the devil is won or lost. If we allow a sinful thought to go unchallenged, we step outside the protection God has so graciously provided us. Outside His protection, we are no match for the devil. If we will cast every thought of immorality and unscriptural practices down when they first invade our mind, we will never cave in to the temptation!

Every test we face must meet the approval of God *in advance*. God looks at the test, then looks at our condition. He understands what we are capable of enduring in the physical, emotional, and spiritual realms. He considers our faith, endurance and weaknesses. Like a gentle, loving Father always interested in our highest good, He never allows the enemy to bring anything against us we cannot overcome.

Testing has to do with living in right relationship with God and others regardless of the pressure to do otherwise. Testing also has to do with standing on the promises of God. To the person who is tested by God the highest form of reality is what the Word of God has to say on the subject.

The bottom line on the matter is this: Temptation has everything to do with our own lusts and appetites, while tests are for our personal development and spiritual maturity. When we are working our way through a test rather than a temptation, the sounds, sights, and smell of victory are never beyond our reach!

PRACTICAL APPLICATION

The key to success in any test we face is as follows:

- Live within the hedge of protection God has provided for us. Cast down all evil imaginations the moment we recognize their presence! (*See 2 Cor. 10:3-5.*)
- Put on the whole armor of God daily. Understand our battle is not with flesh and blood, but “against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the darkness

of this age, against spiritual hosts of wickedness in the heavenly places.” (*See Eph. 6:10-12.*)